We understood. Meg told him we knew how he felt. The press, the paps, they were awful. Impossible to totally ignore what's written, she acknowledged. But please do try to ignore them *in person*. Ignore anyone who approaches, Daddy. Be on guard against anyone who pretends to be your best friend. He seemed to be listening. He started to sound as if he was in a better place, mentally.

Then, the Saturday before the wedding, Jason phoned us. *We've got a problem.*

What?

The Mail on Sunday *is going to run a story saying that Meg's father has been working with the paps and, for money, has staged some candid photos.*

We immediately phoned Meg's dad, told him what was coming. We asked if it was true. Had he staged a bunch of candid photos for money?

No.

Meg said: *We might be able to kill this story, Daddy, but if it turns out you're lying, we'll never be able to kill a false story about ourselves, or our children, again. So this is serious. You must tell us the truth.*

He swore that he'd never staged any photos, that he hadn't taken part in any such charade, that he didn't know the pap in question.

Meg whispered to me: *I believe him*.

In that case, we told him, leave Mexico right now: A whole new level of harassment is about to rain down on you, so come to Britain. Now. We'll arrange for an apartment where you can hole up safely until your flight.

Air New Zealand, first class, booked and paid for by Meg.

We would immediately send a car with private security to pick him up.

He said he had things to do.

Now Meg's face changed. Something was up.

She turned to me again and sighed: *He's lying.*

The story broke the next morning and it was worse than we feared. There was video of Meg's father meeting the pap at an internet café. There was a series of farcically staged shots, including one of him reading a book about Britain as if studying for the wedding. The photos, reportedly worth a hundred thousand pounds, seemed to prove beyond all doubt that Meg's father had indeed been lying. He'd taken part in this fakery, maybe to make some money, or maybe they had some leverage on him. We didn't know.